4 Nasser, Egypt and Arab Nationalism

POINTS TO CONSIDER
This chapter traces the growth of Arab nationalism, which was closely linked with the name of Nasser, President of Egypt from 1954 until his death in 1970. It examines Nasser's defiance of the West, his undisputed leadership of the Arab world, the union of Egypt and Syria and the gradual decline of Arab nationalism. These are examined under the following headings:

- The growth of Arab nationalism
- The United Arab Republic 1958–61

Key dates

1945	Formation of Arab League
1955	Baghdad Pact formed
	Nasser announced Czech arms deal
1956	Suez crisis
1958	Formation of the United Arab Republic (UAR)
1961	Syria left the UAR
1962–7	Nasser sent military aid to the Yemen
1964	Conference of Arab leaders in Cairo
	Formation of the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO)
1967	Six-Day War
1970	Death of Nasser

Key question
Why did Arab nationalism emerge as a political movement?

1 | The Growth of Arab Nationalism

Key term
Arab nationalism
A movement striving for Arab political unity.

In the early twentieth century the Arabs sought independence from European colonial rule. Countries such as Syria, Lebanon and Palestine were ruled by the Turks while Egypt was dominated by the British. Many Arabs embraced the idea of **Arab nationalism**. This concept was rooted in the feeling of sharing the same language, Arabic, and the same religion, Islam (although a tiny minority of Arabs are non-Muslim). But it was more than that because it had a political dimension: the desire for Arab political unity, even to establish a single Arab state. In the First World War, Arab nationalism was boosted by the Arab Revolt of 1916 in which an Arab army fought against the Turks in the Middle East. It was further strengthened, after the war, in